Again one gets the sense that the British foreign secretary was revelling somewhat in Persia's current difficulties with the Bolsheviks, seeing it almost as karmic retribution for having snubbed the Anglo-Persian Agreement.

By 1923 then, it would appear that things were on the up for Britain. When it came to Persia, Loraine declared in November that 'Russian shares politically are declining, and ours are undergoing a steady rise'.[42] *Loraine's policy of non-interference and Rothstein's difficulties had combined to create a relatively comfortable position for Britain. A report by the Interdepartmental Committee on Eastern Unrest (IDCEU) in June 1923 reiterated the fact that the Bolsheviks were making little ideological headway in Persia.*[43] *Indeed, such was the growing confidence in London that when some suggested increasing British propaganda in Persia there was little enthusiasm for the idea. The sheer relentlessness of Rothstein's activities had made a few officials nervous enough to advocate a counter campaign. As one observer pointed out, such British propaganda need not be anti-Bolshevik, rather pro-British; defensive, not offensive, and involve the establishment of pro-British newspapers, and the support of local Mullahs to act as pro-British agents.*[44] *In his memorandum on Soviet propaganda in Persia, Saunders had agreed that to combat Rothstein's work, Britain would need to start subsidising newspapers and even open up its own press bureau. As Saunders pointed out, however, this would cost a considerable amount, and it was questionable whether the results would justify the expenditure.*[45] *In the opinion of R. Bridgeman, if Britain was to try to strengthen its position in Persia, it should do so through more subtle yet substantial forms of propaganda, such as founding local schools and hospitals. In Bridgeman's words, if money were to be spent, it should 'be spent on the Persians rather than against the Russians' – a far cry from the Russian-centric policies advocated by the likes of Cox in 1918.*[46]

Unsurprisingly, Reading agreed with the idea of trying to cultivate Persian friendship rather than worrying about the Bolsheviks.[47] Indeed, the Indian government had been advocating just such a course of action since the end of the First World War. As it was, it had taken a number of years, a failed agreement, an embarrassing military rout, incompetent Bolshevik officials and the ascendancy of an astute British ambassador for the British